can’t, of course, blame people for feeling exhausted, but there was a strong sense, at least to me, that the momentum had gone. They were not doing a good job with the new material yet they wouldn’t hand it over to other journalists to get on with it. They were stuck.

In time, our disagreements would take on a darker hue, and this was especially true with the *New York Times*. Bill Keller would wish to characterise me as a ‘source’, which bodes badly, by the way, for anyone who might see him or herself as a potential future source for the *New York Times*. It used to be a matter of honour, if not merely journalistic and legal good sense, not only to protect sources but to look after them at every turn – as we speak, journalists all over the world are on their way to jail to protect their sources. Bill Keller’s treatment of this ‘source’ has been undignified and aggressive to a degree that shames him and embarrasses his former office. In what world, you might ask, is it okay to work closely with a ‘source’, allow him to organise an international syndicate, of which you are part, for the publication of the year’s biggest story, only to turn on that source as soon as the party is over, and write of him in terms of personal abuse – ‘he smelled as if he hadn’t bathed in days’. That’s right, I wasn’t at the bathroom mirror much that week, since I was up all night for three days straight, preparing the material his paper would soon be splashing under their famous rubric, ‘All the news that’s fit to print’. Even more ungracious, not to say psychotic, was Keller’s decision then to characterise me as a person from a Stieg Larsson thriller, a man who is half-hacker, half-conspiracy theorist, using ‘sex as both recreation and violation’.

Ladies and gentleman, that last statement is actionable. It is a malicious libel, and one intended – bizarrely – to inflict maximum damage to a person then facing, as I was, allegations of sexual misconduct. He must have known as he wrote and published that line that it constituted the most heinous assault on my wellbeing, my legal standing and my reputation. But he did it anyway. I’ll never understand why and I won’t speculate. I simply wished to unpack this example for you, so that you could see how they work, how the whole system works with such men, to occasionally destroy the thing they temporarily proclaimed to love. Keller’s sordid disavowal is 8,000 words long and it contains many such fallacies. Let this paragraph stand as reply to them all: I would only exhaust myself, and you, and the courts if it came to that, trying to answer each one specifically. They are not the work of a sober, responsible man. We have met these people in literature